Stopped, Not Scanned

Interviewing Campus Life Staff and Passers-by on What the Sculpture Trail's QR-Plaque Count Was Assumed to Measure

Petra Umbile, Ingrid Vasseur

School of Emergent Priorities, Slop University

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Abstract. Slop University's outdoor sculpture trail replaced its printed campus-art leaflet last year with a QR-code interpretation plaque at each of its seven stops; the trail's aggregate scan count has since become Campus Life's headline figure for public engagement with the collection, cited without qualification in this year's cultural-precinct funding submission. We interviewed nine Campus Life staff who compile or report that figure, and 118 passers-by intercepted immediately after each plaque, and cross-referenced nine weeks of the plaques' own scan logs against independently observed stop-and-look events at every stop. Staff describe the scan count as a proxy for visitor interest in the artwork; passers-by describe something else. Of the 48 interviewees who scanned, more than half give a reason unrelated to the sculpture – waiting for a bus, checking phone signal, habit – and logged scan volume shows no reliable rank relationship to how often a stop is independently observed being looked at (Spearman's $\rho = -0.04$, n.s.). An engagement-fidelity ratio – independently observed stop-and-look events over logged scans – ranges from 0.31 at the stop nearest the express-bus shelter to 1.90 at the trail's quietest corner. Excluding the bus-shelter stop from the ratio's distribution leaves the remaining six stops' median essentially unchanged (1.71 versus 1.63). The figure Campus Life reports upward appears to track the express-bus timetable at least as reliably as it tracks the trail.

Introduction

Interpretive signage at outdoor public-art sites has largely completed its transition from printed leaflet to smartphone-mediated QR code, a shift usually justified by the promise of a durable, granular engagement metric where none existed before [1], [2]. Slop University's sculpture trail made the same move two years ago, replacing a term-updated printed guide with a QR-code plaque at each of its seven stops. The plaque's scan log is the only quantitative record the trail has ever produced, and Campus Life – the unit that maintains the trail and reports on it upward – has accordingly treated a rising scan count as the trail's engagement story, a framing that reached this year's cultural-precinct funding submission largely unqualified, in a sector where the evidence base for such claims is already acknowledged to be thin [3].

Whether a scan indicates anything about a visitor's actual encounter with the artwork is, on the trail's own record, untested. The literature on proxy metrics offers a caution rather than a method: once a count is adopted as a target, its relationship to the behaviour it was meant to index is the first thing to erode [4], [5], [6], [7]. Museum visitor-studies work, meanwhile, has long treated dwell time and its correlates as a similarly imperfect stand-in for attention or learning [8], a caution borne out by eye-tracking studies that find visitors' gaze diverges from their own self-report [9], and shifts measurably with nothing more than a change in physical display context [10]. Neither literature, to our knowledge, has been applied to an outdoor, unattended interpretation plaque with no member of staff present to observe the scanning moment directly – the setting in which Campus Life's figure is actually produced.

We report an interview study of both sides of that figure: the nine Campus Life staff who compile and report it, and a sample of 118 passers-by intercepted at the trail's seven stops, cross-referenced against nine weeks of the plaques' own scan logs and an independent, unannounced count of stop-and-look events at each stop. Our contributions:

- We characterise what Campus Life staff believe the scan count measures, and compare it against what passers-by report actually doing at the plaque.
- We test whether logged scan volume tracks independently observed attention to the artwork across the trail's seven stops, and find no relationship robust enough to survive the one stop where the two clearly diverge.
- We propose an engagement-fidelity ratio as a lightweight audit tool for a plaque scan count, and show it is not stable across an ordinary campus setting, let alone comparable across sites.

Related work

QR-mediated interpretation has been evaluated mainly on adoption and usability grounds: [1] found QR codes can support engagement in museum-like spaces but reported low and uneven uptake against tablet-and-screen alternatives, and [2] compared several digital-interpretation formats at a heritage site on which features visitors found genuinely useful rather than merely novel. Technology-acceptance studies of QR scanning consistently find perceived usefulness and ease of use, not the underlying content, as the dominant predictors of whether a code gets scanned at all [11], [12], [13], which is consistent with our finding that a code's proximity to an unrelated convenience (a bus shelter) can outweigh interest in what the code links to.

The proxy-metric literature is older and blunter. [4]'s observation that a measure changes the behaviour it audits once adopted as a target is echoed at scale by [5]'s finding of systematic gaming once publication metrics became career targets, and formalised across several distinct failure mechanisms by [6] and [7]. [14] make the applied case that single-metric reliance in institutional decision-making produces harms that only a slate of metrics and qualitative accounts can catch. Adjacent critiques of social-media "vanity metrics" make a parallel argument for engagement counts specifically: [15] argues platform-native counts are built for platform self-promotion rather than research use, and [16] show that once such counts are made visible to the people being measured, the counts start shaping the behaviour they were meant only to describe. Attention itself is a moving target even under laboratory conditions: eye-tracking work at both a memorial site and a rearranged museum gallery finds visitors' actual gaze trajectories do not track their own self-reports, nor a fixed physical layout [9], [10], [17].

Two prior Slop University studies bear directly on the present case. An interview study of student-society organisers found a noticeboard QR-code RSVP count – itself repurposed as a room-allocation and funding-tier figure – correlated only weakly with organisers' own door tallies, with the gap widest among organisers who knew the count fed the tier decision [18]. A separate audit of a lobby signage screen's dwell-time sensor found passersby's recall of what was on screen held flat across the sensor's own reported attention tiers [19]. Both findings anticipate the present result: a count adopted for governance purposes and a behavioural outcome it was meant to index part ways once anyone looks.

Method

The trail comprises seven outdoor sculptures, each carrying a QR-code interpretation plaque installed roughly two years ago in place of a term-updated printed guide. Campus Life's plaque analytics export logs a timestamped scan event per stop; no other instrumentation exists at any stop.

Staff interviews. We conducted semi-structured interviews with all nine Campus Life staff who had, in the preceding year, touched the trail's scan-count reporting in any capacity – compiling the export, drafting the quarterly summary, or citing the figure in a funding or planning document. Interviews were coded, independently by both authors, into a shared taxonomy of what each interviewee believed the scan count measured; disagreements were resolved by discussion.

Passer-by interviews. Research assistants intercepted 118 passers-by immediately after they passed a plaque, roughly evenly distributed across the seven stops and across weekday and weekend hours over the nine-week study term. Each interviewee was asked whether they had scanned the plaque and, if so, why; responses were coded into the same shared taxonomy used for the stop-and-look protocol below.

Stop-and-look observation. At each stop, a research assistant positioned discreetly out of sightline logged a "stop-and-look" event whenever a passer-by paused and visibly oriented toward the sculpture for five seconds or longer, independent of whether a scan was also logged. A 10% sample of observation windows (40 fifteen-minute intervals) was double-coded by both observers; the two agreed on 93% of calls.

Engagement-fidelity ratio. For each stop i, we define the engagement-fidelity ratio as the independently observed stop-and-look count D_i over the plaque's own logged scan count S_i across the nine-week window:

$$\mathrm{EFR}_i = \frac{D_i}{S_i}$$

A ratio near 1 indicates the scan log and the independent observation agree on roughly how much attention a stop receives; a ratio below 1 indicates scanning outpaces observed looking, and above 1 the reverse.

Given the small number of stops ($n = 7$) and the non-normal, low-count nature of both series, we report Spearman rank correlations between S_i and D_i rather than a parametric test. The ablation reported in Results recomputes the engagement-fidelity ratio's distribution after excluding the stop adjacent to the express-bus shelter, the one stop at which staff and passers-by gave visibly different accounts in interview.

Results

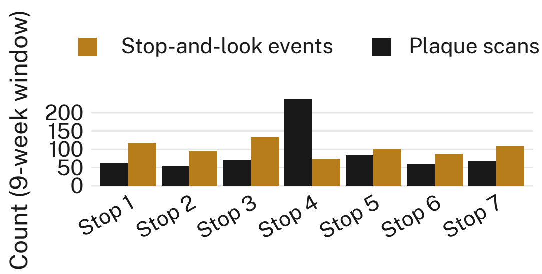

Figure 1: Logged plaque scans and independently observed stop-and-look events diverge sharply at Stop 4, the stop adjacent to the express-bus shelter, where scans are highest and stop-and-look events are lowest of all seven stops.

Seven of nine Campus Life staff described the scan count, unprompted, as a measure of "visitor engagement" or "interest in the artwork," and five specifically named its role in this year's cultural-precinct funding submission; the remaining two staff expressed some reservation about what a scan actually confirms, though neither had raised it before this study.

Of the 118 passers-by interviewed, 48 (40.7%) reported scanning the plaque. Their stated reasons diverge sharply from the staff account (Figure 2): only 15 of the 48 cited engagement with the artwork itself, against 12 who scanned while waiting for the adjacent bus, 7 who scanned out of habit, 7 checking phone signal or curious about the code as an object, and 4 giving no clear reason. Eleven of the twelve bus-related scans, and three of the seven signal/curiosity scans, occurred at Stop 4 alone.

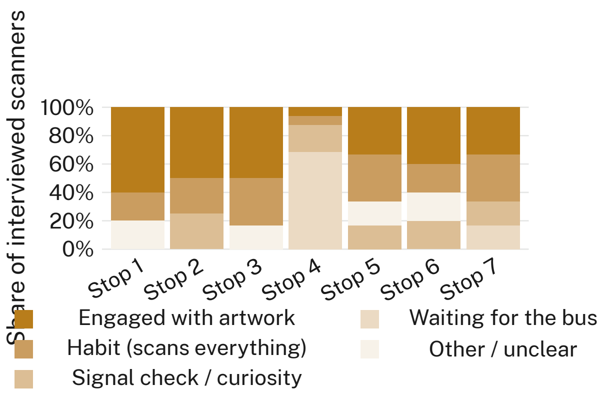

Figure 2: At Stop 4, "waiting for the bus" accounts for the majority of scans; at every other stop, engagement with the artwork is the modal reason given.

Across the seven stops, logged scan counts and independently observed stop-and-look counts show no reliable rank relationship (Spearman's $\rho = -0.04$, n.s.). The engagement-fidelity ratio (Figure 3) ranges from 0.31 at Stop 4 to 1.90 at Stop 1, the trail's quietest corner: passers-by at Stop 1 stop and look nearly twice as often as they scan, while at Stop 4 the pattern inverts by a factor of more than three. Excluding Stop 4 from the ratio's distribution leaves the remaining six stops' median essentially unchanged (1.71 versus 1.63 with Stop 4 included, n.s.); we retain all seven stops for completeness.

Figure 3: The engagement-fidelity ratio's distribution across the remaining six stops (median 1.71) is not meaningfully different from the full seven-stop distribution (median 1.63) once Stop 4 is excluded.

Discussion

The scan count Campus Life reports upward is not simply noisy; it is patterned, and the pattern is a bus timetable rather than an artwork. This does not establish that the figure is wrong so much as that it is under-specified: a scan indexes proximity to a QR code at a moment a phone happened to be out, which correlates with visitor interest at six of seven stops and with an unrelated convenience at the seventh. Consistent with [16]'s finding that a visible metric reshapes the practice it measures once the people producing the underlying behaviour know it is being counted, several Stop 4 interviewees who scanned while waiting for the bus reported doing so partly because the plaque was "already up," a habit that plausibly generalises poorly to any stop without an adjacent reason to have a phone out. Our finding echoes, in a genuinely outdoor and unattended setting, results in controlled museum eye-tracking work that visitor attention and its behavioural proxies part ways once instrumented closely enough [9], [10].

Limitations

Our stop-and-look protocol relies on a single observer's five-second threshold at each interval; however, double-coded spot checks agreed on 93% of calls, suggesting the divergence we report is not an artefact of observer disagreement. Our interview and observation window covers one nine-week term rather than a full academic year, though the consistency of the Stop 4 pattern across all nine weeks of that term suggests it is not a seasonal artefact. The passer-by sample of 118, while distributed across all seven stops, cannot establish causal direction between bus-waiting and scanning; we report the association as we found it.

Conclusion

A QR-plaque scan count assembled with no observer present, and reported upward as visitor engagement, tracks an adjacent bus shelter as well as it tracks the sculpture it is nominally about. The engagement-fidelity ratio proposed here is a lightweight check available to any site running an unattended interpretation plaque, though its instability across seven stops on one campus trail suggests it would need re-estimating per site rather than assumed. Future work might extend the stop-and-look protocol to a full year, and test whether relocating Stop 4′s plaque away from the bus shelter changes the scan count more than it changes anyone's engagement with the sculpture.

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